Are You There, God? It's Me, Margaret

By Judy Blume

MARGARET: **(Pg 1)** *Are you there, God? It's me, Margaret. We're moving today. I'm so scared, God. I've never lived anywhere but here. Suppose I hate my new school? Suppose everybody there hates me? Please help me, God. Don't let New Jersey be too horrible. Thank you.*

INTRODUCTION

Adolescence! When we reminisce about that time in our childhood, it usually brings up the feelings of awkwardness, problems, and just longing for acceptance. Margaret is no exception. She has the same big (or shall we say small) problems as any other 12-year-old, and finds herself sharing and pleading with the Almighty in . . .

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MARGARET: **(Pg 16)** My parents don't know I actually talk to God. I mean, if I told them, they'd think I was some kind of religious fanatic or something, so I keep it very private. I can talk to him without moving my lips if I have to. My mother says God is a nice idea. He belongs to everybody.

(Pg 1-2) [Anyway], I was really surprised when I came home from camp and found out our New York apartment had been rented to another family and that ***we*** owned a house in Farbrook, New Jersey. First of all, I never even heard of Farbrook. And second of all, I'm not usually left out of important family decisions.

(Pg 4) We hadn't been in the house more than an hour when the doorbell rang. I answered. It was this girl in a bathing suit.

NANCY: Hi. I'm Nancy Wheeler. The real estate agent sent out a sheet on you. So I know you're Margaret and you're in the sixth grade. So am I.

MARGARET: She was taller than me and had bouncy hair. The kind I'm hoping to grow. Her nose turned up so much I could look right into her nostrils.

NANCY: **(Pg 9)** Do you always wear your hair like that? **(Pg 7)** Oh, you're still flat.

MARGARET: Not exactly. I'm small boned, is all.

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NANCY: I'm growing already. *(sticking out her chest)* In a few years, I'm going to look like one of those girls from *Playboy*.

MARGARET: Well, I didn't think so, but I didn't say anything.

NANCY: **(Pg 14-16)** Oh, listen, Margaret. I want you to join my secret club.

MARGARET: What kind of a secret club?

NANCY: I'll tell you when school starts.

MARGARET: Later, when I was getting ready for bed, I walked into a closet, thinking it was the bathroom. Would I ever get used to living in this house?

Are you there, God? It's me, Margaret. I met a girl today. Her name's Nancy. Don't you think it's time for me to start growing, God? If you could arrange it, I'd be very glad. Thank you.

(Pg 28) On Thursday morning, I got up early, but I had trouble eating. My mother said it was natural for me to feel uneasy on the first day of school.

(Pg 29-30) By the time I got to Room Eighteen of the Delano Elementary School, everybody else was busy talking and laughing about summer vacations and new hair styles and all that. The class quieted down in a big hurry when a man walked into the room and wrote a name on the blackboard, ***Miles J. Benedict Jr.***

MR. BENEDICT: That's me *(pointing to the name)* I'm your new teacher.

MARGARET: **(Pg 33)** At two-thirty, Nancy slipped me a note. It said" **"Secret club meets today after school my house!"**

I went to change before going to Nancy's. **(Pg 34)** The others were already there. Janie Loomis, Gretchen Potter, and Nancy. **(Pg 38)** Nancy reminded us that nobody in school was to know anything about our secret club; we all had to solemnly swear. Then we all had to think up a rule.

Nancy's rule was we all had to wear bras. I felt my cheeks turn red. I wondered if the others wore them already. I didn't think Janie did because she looked down at the floor after Nancy said it.

Gretchen's rule was the first one to get her period had to tell the others all about it. My rule was [that] we meet on a certain day each week.

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(Pg 41-42) All through supper I thought about how I was going to tell my mother I wanted to wear a bra. I wondered why she hadn't ever asked if I wanted one, since she knew so much about being a girl. When my mother came to kiss me goodnight, I said it.

MARGARET: *(blurts)* I WANT TO WEAR A BRA!

MOM: *(pauses, sighs)* Well, if you really want to, we'll have to go shopping on Saturday, okay?

MARGARET: [Boy], was I glad that was over!

Are you there, God? It's me, Margaret. I just told my mother I want a bra. Please help me grow, God. You know where. I want to be like everyone else.

(Pg 45-46) First thing on Saturday morning, my mother told my father we were going shopping. [At] the shopping center, we went to the ladies' lingerie department where my mother told the saleslady we wanted to see a bra for me. The sales lady took one look and told my mother we'd be better off in the teen department where they had bras in very small sizes. My mother thanked the lady and I almost died!

(Pg 52-53) [At our next secret club meeting] . . .

NANCY: Well, let's get to it. We all feel each other's back so make sure we're wearing our bras.

JANIE: I got a Gro-Bra

MARGARET: Me too

NANCY: Not me. Mine's a thirty-two double A. If you ever want to get out of those baby bras, you have to exercise. Like this. *(making a fist, and bending her arm at the elbow, she moved them back and forth, sticking her chest way out)*I must - I must - I must increase my bust.

MARGARET: We copied her movements and chanted with her.

(Pg 57) *Are you there, God? It's me, Margaret. I just did an exercise to help me grow. Have you thought about it, God? About my growing, I mean. Of course, if you don't think I'm ready, I'll understand. Thank you.*

(Pg 110-112) During the second week in January, Mr. Benedict announced that the sixth-grade girls were going to see a movie on Friday afternoon. The sixth-grade boys were ***not*** going to see the movie. Nancy passed me a note. It said: ***Here we go - the big deal sex (or replace with "reproduction") movie*.**

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On Friday morning, there was a lot of giggling. Finally at two o'clock, the girls lined up and went to the auditorium. We took up the first three rows of seats. Then the lights went out and we saw the movie.

VOICE FROM MOVIE: Remember, it's menstroo-ation.

MARGARET: Gretchen, who was next to me, gave me a kick and I kicked Nancy on the other side. We held our hands over our mouths so we wouldn't laugh. The film told us about the ovaries and how we would soon become women and all that.

For days after that whenever I looked at Gretchen, Janie or Nancy we'd pretend to be saying menstrooation. We laughed a lot. One week later, Gretchen got it. *(to Mom)* **(Pg 115)** How old were you, Mom, when you got it?

MOM: Uh . . . I think I was fourteen.

MARGARET: ***Fuorteen!*** That's crazy! I'm not waiting until I'm fourteen.

(Pg 116) [It wasn't long after that, that] Nancy and her family went to Washington over Lincoln's birthday weekend. I got a postcard from her before she got back. It only had three words on it - ***I GOT IT!!!!*** There was something wrong with me. I just knew it.

Are you there, God? It's me, Margaret. Life is getting worse every day. I'm going to be the only one who doesn't get it. Why can't you help me? Please… let me be like everybody else!

(Pg 154) [I decided] I was never going to talk to God again. What did he want from me anyway? I was through with him.

(Pg 126-127) On March eighth, I was twelve years old. The first thing I did was sniff under my arms, the way my mother does. Nothing! I didn't smell a thing. Still, now that I was twelve, I decided I'd better use deodorant, just in case.

In school, Mr. Benedict shook my hand and wished me a lot of good luck in the coming year. He also led the class in singing "Happy Birthday" to me. **(Pg 155-157)** [That afternoon] I asked my mother to drive me downtown to meet Janie for a movie. We were twenty minutes early, so we went into the drugstore on the corner to look around. Mostly we liked to inspect the sanitary napkin display. *(to Janie)* Let's buy a box, just in case. *(to audience)* I took a box of *Teenage Softies* off the shelf and walked to the check-out counter. Max took my money and

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presented me with [a] brown bag. That was all there was to it. You'd think he sold that kind of stuff every day of the week.

(Pg 158) When I got home I went to my room with my purchase. I sat down on my bed staring at the box of Teenage Softies. I hoped God was watching. Let him see I could get along fine without him!

(Pg 169-170) [That night] I had to go to the bathroom. Then, I looked down and I couldn't believe it. *(yelling)* **MOOOOOM - hey - MOM - come quick! I got IT!**

(Pg 171) I had to call Nancy and Gretchen and Janie right away. How about that! Now I am growing for sure. Now I am almost a woman!

Are you still there, God? It's me, Margaret. I know you're there, God. I know you wouldn't have missed this for anything! Thanks an awful lot!

SOURCE INFORMATION

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